

Combat sports

Many sports, both ancient and modern, have their roots in traditional fighting techniques. These combat sports teach strength and discipline, and help students learn how to defend themselves. Some are better known as martial arts.

TYPES OF COMBAT SPORTS

Some combat sports have developed from very old ways of fighting, while others have been around for just a few decades. Most focus on one of three types of attack: punches, kicks, and other strikes; throwing, holding, and pinning; or using weapons.

PUNCHES, KICKS, AND OTHER STRIKES

KUNG FU: TAOLU

Kung fu takes many forms. The most popular is taolu, a form of *wushu*.

KUNG FU: SANSHOU

Sanshou is a Chinese martial art similar to kickboxing. It is never practised with weapons.

KUNG FU: T'AI CHI

Based on slow, flowing movements, this is a gentle, meditative form of kung fu.

BOXING

The Ancient Greeks boxed, but modern boxing follows rules set 150 years ago in England.

THAI BOXING

Unlike Western boxers, Thai boxers attack with feet, elbows, and knees as well as fists.

CAPOEIRA

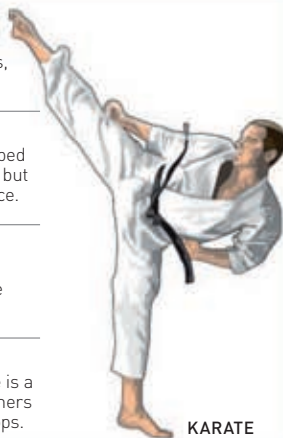
African slaves in Brazil developed capoeira. It looks like a dance, but it is really a form of self-defence.

TAEKWONDO

The name of this 20th-century Korean martial art means "the way of the foot and fist".

KARATE

Originating from Japan, karate is a form of self-defence. Practitioners do not use any weapons or props.



KARATE

THROWING, HOLDING, AND PINNING

JUJITSU

This Japanese martial art drew on ancient Indian and Chinese fighting techniques.

JUDO

Based on jujitsu, judo developed in the 1800s. It involves throwing, grappling, and striking.

SUMO WRESTLING

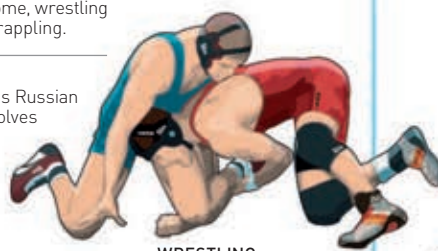
This sport is most associated with Japan, but it originated in China in the 3rd century BCE.

WRESTLING

As popular today as it was in Ancient Greece and Rome, wrestling involves one-to-one grappling.

SOMBO

Very like wrestling, this Russian combat sport also involves punches and kicks.



WRESTLING

USING WEAPONS

KALARIPAYIT

One of the world's oldest martial arts, kalaripayit developed in Ancient India.

FENCING

This sport developed from sword fighting in the 1500s. Many of its terms are French.

KYUDO

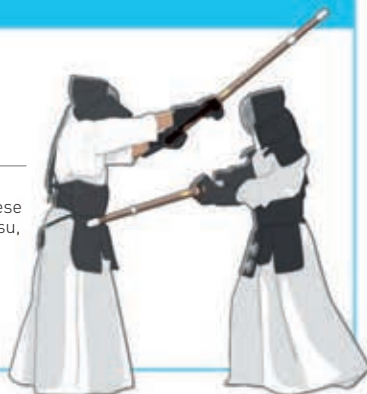
Samurai warriors practised an early form of kyudo, which is similar to archery.

ESKRIMA

Meaning "skirmish", eskrima was developed in the Philippines in the 16th century.

KENDO

Full of ritual, this Japanese sport is based on kenjutsu, an 11th-century form of sword-fighting.



KENDO

KUNG FU: TAOLU

Taolu is a form of kung fu in which competitors show off routines on a padded mat. Their moves include punches, balances, jumps, sweeps, and throws. Some moves are performed bare-handed, and some with weapons.

TAOLU WEAPONS

In taolu, competitors handle various traditional Chinese weapons. Working alone or in pairs, they aim to be as graceful as possible.

GUN (TYPE OF STAFF), 210 cm (7 ft)

JIAN (SWORD), 103 cm (3.4 ft)

DAO (CURVED SWORD), 98 cm (3.25 ft)

NANDAO (BROADSWORD), 97 cm (3.25 ft)



Taijijian sword is 110 cm (3.6 ft) long

Swishing tassels emphasize the moves

Chinese tunic worn over loose trousers

SEATED STANCE

In this stance, called *xie bu*, the competitor wraps one thigh over the other. The front foot stays flat on the floor.

CROUCH STANCE

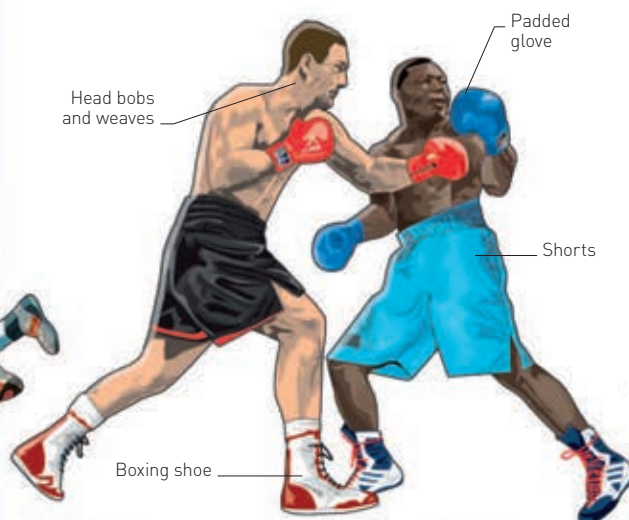
This move, known as *pu bu*, is a very low squat. One arm arches over the head to counterbalance the crouching.

HORSE STANCE

This powerful position is known as *ma bu* in Chinese. The tops of the thighs must stay parallel to the floor.

BOXING

In boxing, two opponents try to punch each other, while avoiding punches themselves. They score points for different punches to their opponent's head and upper body. The winner is the boxer who scores most points or who knocks out his or her opponent.



Head bobs and weaves

Padded glove

Shorts

Boxing shoe

FIGHTING GEAR

Groin guards are optional, but gloves and mouth guards must be worn. Head guards are mandatory for women's contests.



GROIN GUARD



GLOVES



MOUTH GUARD



HEAD GUARD



JAB

A stiff jab is the basic punch used by all boxers. For a perfect jab, the boxer has to fully extend his arm.



HOOK

Hooks are delivered to the side of the head or body. The best hooks are those an opponent does not see coming.



UPPERCUT

This powerful punch is delivered on to the opponent's chin from below. It often results in a knockout.